

Field day

Of hidden talents and uncommon interests

Everyone earns themselves a sobriquet at one point or the other in their life. Tony Blair has lately earned the unflattering US Foreign Minister tag and Billy Bob Thornton is serial groom in waiting after his fifth divorce. Jiten Gandhi, our in-house photographer earned himself the nickname Jiten *Jholer* during his recent trip to the north. [*Jholer*, *Mumbaiya Hindi*, from *Jhol karma: manipulate the situation to your advantage*.]

Now don't get us wrong, Jiten Bhai, as we call him, is as sweet and unassuming as they come. But he is also a wandering trader—pick up some candy from someone's table on the way to the Photo Studio, exchange it with someone for a cigarette which in turn will serve as rental for the headphones he borrows as a prop from someone else. He is known to pull out the most amazing things from his multi-pocketed photographer's jacket. But on the trip to the capital to distribute the Zero1 trophies, he astonished his fellow travellers Bhavesh Thakor, the Digit marketing manager and Shubendu Nath, our brand manager, with his tricks.

Now travelling with Jiten Bhai is not easy, the man keeps disappearing for short periods at the sniff of a photo opportunity. On the Rajdhani Express that was carrying the trio to the capital, food was a problem. Shubendu, is referred to as the black hole—any food within a 5 feet diameter is promptly sucked into his central gravity. Bhavesh, a newly married weight watcher was more than glad to place his food in Shubendu's orbit to watch it disappear. A little later, they realised that Jiten Bhai had done the disappearing act again. He returned a while later with a friendly waiter and asked them if they needed anything extra and within a few minutes, there were extra bowls of dahi, ice cream, soup and what have you.

Around tea-time, pangs of hunger struck Shubendu again. When asked what he would like to eat, he replied,

chicken tandoori. It seemed unlikely that he could get the bird, considering that this was a train and it was around tea-time. But Jiten bhai, as usual, did his vanishing act and appeared a few moments later with a waiter and chicken tandoori in tow!

But the best trick that Jiten bhai pulled was after the trio reached Delhi. After the round of visiting the Zero1 award winners and distributing the trophies, Bhavesh decided to catch up with some friends in Delhi. He made plans to meet Jiten and Shubendu back at the guest house and go for dinner—what

drink. Apparently, Jiten had befriended the local fruit vendor and coaxed him to lay out the spread from his own stock of fruits. After satisfying their pangs, the vendor invited them over for the next day and promised to cook them some mutton! How Jiten Bhai pulled this off, remains a secret! But it sure earned him the nickname!

IIT Techfest

This year at the IIT Mumbai Techfest, of which Digit was the official Techfest magazine, our writer Srinivasan Ramakrishnan and copy editor Mitali Parekh were sent out to cover the event. Now IIT is the place where all the engineering students want to go—its lush lawns, spacious lecture halls and ultra-cool labs are stuff that engineering dreams are made off. Now Srin and Mitali aren't really the best of tag-team duo. One is a verbose chronicler of technology; the other is scissor-happy with words. One is a technology enthusiast, the other a nature lover. One speaks in garbled gigahertz, the other in... you get the point!

According to reports, Srin was like a wide-eyed six-year-old in Disneyland, running to each event, cheering the robots at Yantriki, dropping his jaw at the workshops and guest lecturers. Mitali, on the other hand, sat in the lawn and wondered how much of the country's cerebral resources was going to be exported to the United States come June-July. Meeting the IIT faculty was no less than meeting an A-list celebrity for Srin, Mitali couldn't understand why he was making all the fuss over a science/math teacher—subjects she didn't particularly take to in her academic years.

But the Aibo Soccer match had both techno-geek Srin and dog-lover Mitali clapping in glee. Stranger things have bonded people together—we didn't particularly mind as long as they got the Firsthand story out on time! ■



ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar

Bhavesh had forgotten was that he had the keys to the guest house. So our in-house photographer and the brand manager sat outside the guest house in 6 degrees of the Northern winter waiting for Bhavesh to return. Bhavesh, on the other hand was being forced by his friends to stay for dinner, so he calls up the guesthouse, still unaware of the fate of his colleagues and obviously, no one picked up the phone. Thinking that they'd left for dinner without him, he proceeded to dine with his friends. Meanwhile, Shubendu was making calls to his friends from the local PCO as Jiten Bhai wandered around the area. When Shubendu was done, Jiten Bhai led him to an open ground where a table was spread out and laid with chopped fruit and